

film festival Gender Benders

DELHI Women in deep comas. Transvestite fathers. Abusive priests. Pregnant nuns. Women matadors. In Pedro Almodovar's baroque world, anything is possible. In *What Have I Done to Deserve This?* (1984), a dysfunctional family has a pet lizard and a grandmother who keeps bread under lock and key. In *High Heels* (1991), a mother and daughter share a lover, who turns up dead. In *Live Flesh* (1997), a woman gives birth to a baby in a city bus. In *Bad Education* (2004), a man impersonates a transvestite who plays a woman. In Almodovar's luscious landscape of lust, sin and inescapable duty, women and men blur into each



A scene from Almodovar's electric *Bad Education*

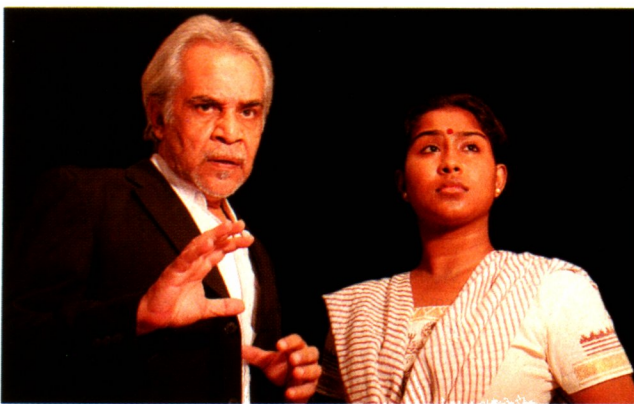
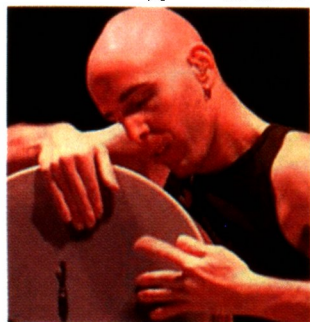
other, as do good and bad. His films, presented by the Embassy of Spain at the India International Centre in Delhi (seven-film retrospective till February 27) are masterpieces of extravagant excess.

Watch Javier Bardem in *Live Flesh* before he became a Hollywood star and Penelope Cruz in *All About My Mother* (1999) before she became an international celebrity.

Pity they're not showing *Law of Desire* (1987) and *Women on the Verge of a Nervous Breakdown* (1988), which had Antonio Banderas at his unspoilt peak. Almodovar is one of the world's greatest living filmmakers and certainly the most consistent chronicler of women, in all their eternal goodness and occasional ghastliness. Take a deep breath and go. **by Kaveree Bamzai**

recommendations Lords of the Arts

MUMBAI Gowri Ramnarayan has made a smooth transition from being a critic to writing and directing plays. A prolific playwright, her work has been widely appreciated in Chennai. She is now staging her plays in Delhi and Bangalore as well. Her latest work *Water Lilies: A Trilogy* will play **Zohar Fresco, percussionist**



A scene from *Water Lilies: A Trilogy*

at Prithvi Theatre next week, kicking off Prithvi theatre's Poetry Fest 2008. Written, designed and directed by her, the trilogy deals with emotions, relationships, secrets and ideologies. Using multimedia projections and poetry, it is a recurring image of Monet's *Water Lilies*. February 17, Morning, Prithvi Theatre.

by Nirmala Ravindran

CHENNAI The second annual Earthsync Festival will soar through spiritual, Indian classical, devotional, Middle-Eastern, western and electronic music forms. See video art and attend a music gala comprising Asian musicians. Buddhist chants, folk music, Sufi songs and Carnatic sounds will all be heard at Sir Muthu Venkatasubba Rao Concert Hall, February 17.

music reviews Melodies Galore



Music Today
Rs 295

CATHERINE POTTER
The album features Potter's world music ensemble.

She is a disciple of flute maestro Pandit Hariprasad Chaurasia. The highlight of the album is *Hariji's Dhun*. The melody draws from the Bengali boatmen. This *Bhatiyali Dhun* as it is popularly known, is synonymous with the legendary flautist and features a tribute by the artiste to her guru.



Sony-BMG
Rs 175

IT ROCKS
This is a good collection of hits from films and Indi-pop

albums. The songs range from *Ya ali* from *Gangster* to *In dino* from *Life in a Metro* and *Garaj bars* from *Paap*. The bonus is songs like *Silk Route's Dooba dooba*, *Junoon's Sayonee* and *Strings' Na janay kyun*. Easy listening on a long drive.

BEYOND BOUNDARIES



Eros

Music composer Aadesh Srivastava has donned the role of singer in

this Indi-pop album. The melodies are joyful and range from the energetic Punjabi number *Chak de chak de*, a raga-based Sufiyana song, *Ishq sufiyana ishq sufiyana*, to the hip-hop number, *One for the road* amongst others. Srivastava's voice has been technologically enhanced to keep the style of the song in mind.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit